

Please read the following text carefully. The questions later in the study refer to it:

Imagine you find yourself in the year 2030. Technological advances in social robotics and Artificial Intelligence (AI) made it possible for the company HomeTec to develop a new social robot known under its brand name HomeMate:

June and Gary Miller were professionally ambitious mid-forties. They lived with their three children in a house in an attractive neighborhood on the outskirts of a large city. To make everyday life easier, the Millers decided to order HomeMate.

Gary was impressed by HomeMate's initial ability to operate autonomously in the Millers' home. HomeMate understood everyday social situations and responded according to social norms, such as greeting visitors. The latest approaches to robot learning and a sophisticated sensory system enabled HomeMate to learn and adapt its behavior. As a result, HomeMate was soon able to call family members by name and interact with each family member in an appropriate manner. Based on body features such as facial expression or tone of voice, HomeMate was able to recognize the Millers' states of mind and, for example, comforted the children when they cried. Sometimes June and Gary felt guilty because they tended to send Rob ahead when the kids were in a bad mood or needed emotional support.

HomeMate's human-like design and increasing ability to interact with the Millers led the children to name the robot "Rob". While Rob was playing with the children, it appeared as if they were having real conversations. Only upon closer inspection could one notice that Rob's responses and behavior were quite stereotypical after all. But nevertheless, the children saw the robot more and more as a companion. June noticed with concern that her kids' general behavior was slowly changing. One of her sons even told her that his friends were exhausting and that he would prefer to play with Rob.

When the kids were home alone, the parents used Rob's surveillance feature to make sure they weren't doing anything wrong. June had already secretly overheard conversations between her daughter and her first boyfriend. She hadn't been able to resist, but she was actually ashamed of herself. And what if HomeTec, like her, didn't respect privacy and data protection and was surveilling her and her family?

One day, the Millers' son Alex reported that one of his classmates also wanted a HomeMate but that his parents, however, had told him that they did not earn enough money to be able to afford such an expensive robot.